It was coined originally by Theodor Mommsen, and was meant to express that scientific analysis and research must steer clear of every preconceived opinion. But it could not be, nor was it, intended to mean that scientific research needs no presuppositions at all. Scientific thought must link itself to something, and the big question is, *where.* This question has occupied the minds of the most profound thinkers of all epochs and all nations, since time immemorial, from Thales to Hegel, setting in motion all forces of man's imagination and logic. But it has been demonstrated again and again that a final, conclusive answer cannot be found. Perhaps the most impressive proof of this negative finding is that until now all attempts have failed to discover a world view uniformly acceptable, in its general features at least, by all minds capable of judgment. The only conclusion which this fact permits, according to every dictate of reason, is that it is absolutely impossible to place exact science in an *a priori* manner on a universal foundation possessing a fixed and inclusive content.

Thus, at the very outset of our quest for the meaning of exact science, we are confronted by an obstacle which must be a disappointment to everybody who is seriously striving for knowledge. In fact, this obstacle has driven many a critically disposed thinker to join the ranks of the skeptics. And a no less regrettable fact is that there are perhaps just as many, or even more, individuals of the opposite disposition whom the fear of falling victims to skepticism—an ideology which they consider intolerable—drives to look for salvation to prophets of creeds like, for instance, anthroposophy. Such prophets appear on the scene in all epochs, not excepting our own, with their brand new message of salvation, and they often succeed, with an amazing rapidity, in gathering a following of enthusiastic disciples, eventually to make their exit from the stage and to sink back into the all-engulfing abyss of oblivion.

Is there a way out of this fatal dilemma? And where can it be found? This is the first question to claim our attention. I shall attempt to show that there is a positive answer to it, and that this answer will cast a light both on the meaning and limits of exact science. I submit to the judgment of each of you the validity of my proposed resolution of the problem.

I.

If we seek a foundation for the edifice of exact science which is capable of withstanding every criticism, we must first of all tone down our demands considerably. We must not expect to succeed at a stroke, by one single lucky idea, in hitting on an axiom of universal validity, to permit us to develop, with exact methods, a complete scientific structure. We must be satisfied initially